

THE KESTREL OF LANTERN- FALL

Fourth Wall Gaming

CHAPTER ONE — THE LAST SUPPER



The lamps of Lanternfall were coming up along the western face when Sefa Rocksquill saw the haze fold.

She was flying the fourth ring on lamp-patrol, bored, watching the tenders move their small fires wick to wick, and out in the eastern haze the air bunched and folded the way it does around something large that does not want to be seen. A drake. Riding the dead currents in off the empty east, low and slow, and it had not seen her.

She did what her wings were built for. She folded them and fell out of the high amber with the wingspear couched, and she drove the point down through the root of its left wing before it knew the sky held anything but itself. The drake screamed. It tore loose and tumbled and hit the lamp-ring scaffold twelve metres down and smashed its other wing on the bone.

She came down after it. Her hatchet rang off its skull and did nothing she could feel. She set her boot against its neck and hauled on the spear and the spear would not come. She hauled again, harder, and it still would not come — and then the jaws closed on her left arm and the pain went white to the shoulder.

The drake held. It got its weight under it and threw itself over the rim to take her down by the arm into the deep sky, and for a long moment the whole drop pulled at her through the bone of her own arm. She braced and wrenched with everything she had. The grip

broke. The wing-skin tore off her spear-point and the drake fell away alone, turning, getting small, gone into the haze it had come out of. She kept the spear. She always kept the spear.

The lamp-tenders had seen it and they called for Wardens, and two came, and the medic cut the blood-stiff harness off her arm and pressed a dressing flat against the bite.

“A drake doesn’t choose its ground,” he said. “It goes where the wind packs the prey.” He worked while he talked. “This one was thin under the hide. Third eastern stray this month. It wasn’t hunting here because here is good. It was hunting here because the east is empty. Starving things come to the light.” He looked up at her. “You did it a kindness.”

An old Vael on the scaffold, soot to her elbows, said it to no one. “The east haze used to sing with skimmers at dusk. Been quiet since the thaw.”

Sefa flew in to report with her arm splinted to her ribs and the taste of the thing already in her mouth.

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Esk Veil-Torn drafted fliers, not invalids, and she said so.

She stood at the survey table with the eastern charts pinned and the dead-air flags clustered thick along the old lane, and she offered three days’ rest or the dawn launch, and the honesty to choose between them.

“Sooner is better,” Sefa said. “Wouldn’t you say, commander.”

At next light she drew her kit and met Kithrel of the Moults on the eastern launch ledge — the fastest survey-flier on the muster, a Grey-wake survivor with eleven lane-tokens braided into her primaries that she did not talk about. Kithrel set the terms the way she set everything, flat and exact.

“Out to the Veyl shallows along the old east lane. I read the air, you watch the sky. When I say we turn, we turn. The edge doesn’t negotiate.”

“I’ll try to keep up,” Sefa said, and let her lead.

They flew east, and the wind died around them by degrees, the lift going slack under the wing the way a current goes slack. Fifteen kilometres out, where the lane should have been loud with skim-shoals at the turn of the morning, Sefa saw pale shapes standing on a skim-reef in the haze and could not make them out. Kithrel looked once, and something went out of her voice.

“Nine years on this lane. That is none of them.”

They came in high and offset, on terms — first gust of anything wrong, climb and run west — and at four hundred metres Kithrel read the aneroid and stopped reading a number at all.

“Zero. Not low. Zero. There is no breath in this air at all.” She held the dial where Sefa could see it. “The still zone isn’t out at the shallows. It’s here.”

On the reef stood nine figures in wax-bleached robes, evenly spaced, facing east, singing low and together. None of them turned. The air around them was wrong, flat and dead, and drifting between them were pale bells the size of a crouching man, slow, going from singer to singer, settling over the upturned faces and drinking.

They pulled back to a reef-knuckle a kilometre and a half west of the zero line and set a picket behind the bone-spine with the light at their backs, because dead air is one-way ground. They watched. The Choir went from nine voices to seven. The bells went from seven to nine.

“Head home,” Sefa said, when she had seen enough to know the rest. “We don’t need to count them to know what’s going to happen. Next we find the ones who sent these fools out here to die. Fly quiet and fly safe.”

They went west, low and quiet, the wind coming back into their wings like blood into a sleeping hand.

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The threads ran down out of the light, into the under-city.

A foreman at Orrim's Pale-Vats had run night-shift white work in the spring — nine bodies' worth of wax — for a soft-spoken hooded Vael who smelled of shrine-incense and paid over the odds and did not haggle. The nine bundles had gone down, into the condemned bone-galleries under the windlane approach. And the beggars who slept in the under-stair knew of a supper held there every ninth night: robed folk, candles, in the sealed dark. The next was the next night.

The foreman's name was Bele Tarrow, and Sefa went to him with her hands empty.

She found him at a counter-house called the Tallow Cup between the first bell and the second — a big Roak gone soft in the shoulders, grey at the crest, sitting with his back to the wall and his eye on the door, guarding a bowl he was not eating. There was a child's tally-bead bracelet on his wrist, old and worn smooth, and he touched it without knowing he did.

She had the charter in her pocket. She left it there and took the stool beside him.

"You heard about the drake this week?"

"You're the Rocksquill," he said. "The Kestrel."

She let the silence sit and looked at him, and what she read was a frightened man, not a paid one — the fear coming up from below the stair and not down from the guild — and grief already in him for something he had not lost yet.

"Is everyone okay?" she said, gentle. "Anything I could help you with, Bele Tarrow?"

He came apart then, quietly, the way big men do. His girl. Derra, a vat-clerk on his own floor, the best tally-hand in the works. Gone quiet at Winterend, then no sound, then the air going soft around her like wool over the world. A soft-spoken Vael with clean hands had found him at shift's end, and he gave back the words the way you give back a knot that holds your life.

“He said, ‘The silence is not a sickness, foreman. It is an arrival. She will be honored among us, and you may pay her keeping like any loving father pays a dowry.’”

So he paid. Bread and water-jugs and mooring rope, every ninth night, off his own tally, left at the third side-mouth past the under-stair. He had seen her once, at Solstice, let to stand at a curtain and watch her straighten the mats.

“She looked kept,” he said. “That’s all I can say. Kept.”

Nine days ago the asking had changed. Rope in quantity. And lamp-oil — four casks, and four more tonight.

“They sit in the dark down there,” Tarrow said. “They love the dark. So what does a congregation that doesn’t light lamps want with that much oil?”

“Those people who say they’re tending people with the stillness,” Sefa said, “they’re tending the stillness itself.”

He nodded slow, like she had named a thing he had carried alone a long time. “I know. I knew when they asked for the rope. You don’t need rope to tend the sick.”

The soft man gave the orders, he said. A woman with a cantor’s lilt and a big quiet one did what he said. Three ninth-nights back the soft man had worn a new pin at his collar — small worked bone, the shape of a closed hand. A rendering man knows worked bone. Featherwright craft. The guild whose oath was *no one falls*.

He rose for his shift at the second bell. At the door he turned back, and gave her the only thing he had.

“My girl, Warden. Whatever you’re doing down there. My girl.”

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Esk heard all of it and named it in a breath. They were not worshipping under her spire. They were housing the Hushed and the bells together in one room, forty metres under her own launch ledge, and feeding it. She gave the orders cold. Watch the supper. Do not raid it.

“I want the client. Bring me a face.”

She took a falchion from the chart-room rack and put it in Sefa’s hand. “Bring it back with a story or don’t bother bringing it back.” Sefa took it with a quiet prayer, drew a throwing hatchet, and racked her wingspear as too long for the corridors of the dead.

They went down before the next night’s supper, and split at the gallery mouth. Kithrel stayed there in the shadow with three flares and Esk’s runner. Sefa went up the north scaffold into the vault of the supper-room on half-furled wings — dead air bites only half of nothing, and shoves the other half about the room like a held breath let go — and folded onto the high perch and became part of the bone.

The room woke beneath her. The keeper came first: a Vael woman, flat-feathered, a burn-scar on the web of one thumb, an unlit hand-lamp in her grip. She lit the tallow down the half-circle of mats and the chamber went amber, and the shadows climbed the vault toward Sefa. Then six families filed in and took the mats like mourners taking pews. Then the Hushed, led not driven, seven of them, the tallow-flames leaning and guttering as the dead air came in with them. Among them was a small woman with ink worn into the webbing of her fingers, her eyes open and moving and nothing behind them. Derra Tarrow.

Then three came through the felt arch. A big silent Ossuin who took post by the casks. A woman in grey with an ash-censer swinging in her hand. And between them, unhurried, a soft-faced Vael with clean hands and a small closed hand of bone at his collar. Vesh.

He lifted his empty hands to the mats and spoke in a warm, carrying voice.

“Friends. You’ve fed them faithfully, and they’ve grown. Tonight they’re ready to give back what the world gave them — and you’ll have your beloveds returned to the air they came from. All of you. Tonight is the last supper. After this, no one need pay again.”

The big man laid his hand on an oil-cask.

Sefa’s hatchet was already turning in her fingers. She threw it. It went out of the high dark and into the wrist on the cask, and the oil

choked off, and every amber-lit face in the room tipped up toward a perch that had held nothing a heartbeat before.

Vesh had a spark-striker in his clean hand over the spilled oil. He did not crank it.

“A Warden. Of course.” His thumb rested on the wheel. “Come down, feather. You don’t want to be up there when this room goes to sleep. There’s no flying in dead air. And there’s no flying at all once I turn my wrist.”

She rose to her height and rang the falchion out of its sheath for them all to see and threw her voice down. “You’re surrounded, surgeon. The whole draft’s in these galleries.”

“No,” he said, almost kind. “There are no other wings. I’d have heard them. This air carries a lie better than it carries a flock.”

But the families had heard her name the casks. The grey-crested Lanhawk man came up off his mat. “Vesh. He said it was a blessing. He said our daughter would only—”

Vesh sent the big man to the arch and kept the striker, and Sefa stopped wasting breath on him.

“To the flares!” she shouted, the whole launch-deck of her lungs behind it. “Go! The wing’s at the door!”

The families broke for the mouth. Kithrel’s flare went up red and hung, and her voice came thin across the room. “Here! Eyes on the light — move!”

Sefa folded her wings and dropped. Nine metres, straight down, the falchion out front, the dive she was born for — and the dead air took it. Her wings found their half of nothing at the bottom and the dive came wrong and the falchion opened on empty, and Vesh simply leaned a hand’s-width aside as she fell past his shoulder. She wrenched it back with the last thing she had, and the blade came down through the root of his left wing and did not stop. The wing came away. He folded to the floor, and the pin winked once in the tallow-light.

His thumb finished its work on the way down.

The room took a breath of fire. It ran out from where he fell in two bright tongues, one along the swept path toward the mats and one curling back toward the casks, and the dead air did nothing to it but sit there and let it climb. Heat slapped her across the face. The Hushed pulled back from the light, rooted and shuddering.

She took up the dying man to carry him out — the face Esk wanted — and then the first cask began to sing, that rising kettle-shriek of oil going to vapour, and she knew it the way every Warden knows it. She rammed his body into the cask and threw herself the other way, for the girl. The cask burst. It picked her up and threw her and the fire caught in the feathers of her left wing.

She came down at Derra's feet, and the fire on her wing went small. In the dead hush that wrapped the silent girl the flames starved and ducked — and her own breath went thin and flat in her chest, the air giving nothing back.

She could not fly. She gathered the girl against her and held what breath she had and ran for the mouth. Fifteen metres of fire toward a red star. She made ten of them. Then the held breath turned to a fist in her chest and her legs stopped believing in the floor, and she went down five metres short, the dark closing in from every edge.

She did not take the rope for herself. She looped it around Derra and shoved the girl the last terrible distance toward Kithrel.

“Got her — I’ve got her!”

The hush went out of the room on the rope with the girl, and the fire remembered Sefa was there, and the dark won and took her down into it.

Kithrel dropped the line and came back into the fire for her and dragged her clear as a second cask blew.

She woke on the cold bone of the gallery floor, real air sawing into her lungs, the sweetest thing she had ever breathed. Kithrel had two fists in her harness.

“There she is. There she is, you stubborn squill. I went in for you. Cask went off behind us — you owe me a drink.”

The families were out, huddled and coughing in the dark. Derra stood among them, silent, breathing the flat nothing she breathed now, and on the living side of the fire. The supper burned on behind the arch with Vesh in it.

Sefa sat up and looked at her wing. The feathers were burned to black quills, the membrane stiff, the whole of it hanging wrong. She looked at it a long time. Then she looked at Kithrel.

“Fuck,” she said.

“Yeah,” Kithrel said. “That about covers it.”

“I asked you to tell me when I got to do something satisfying.” She looked at the dying fire. “This wasn’t it.”

“Six families walked out,” Kithrel said. “The girl’s standing right there.”

“Let’s go home, Kith.”

“Yeah.” Kithrel got a hand under her bad side and took the weight without being asked. “Let’s go home.”